Evidence Log

Interviews

Competitor	Competitor Type	Primary Focus/Value Proposition
Cleo	Direct Competitor	AI-native conversational chatbot that uses conversational nudges, roasts, and automated rules to encourage saving.
Monarch Money	Direct / Adjacent Competitor	Full-suite household budgeting and financial tracking tool with integrated AI assistance.
YNAB(You need a Budget)	Indirect Competitor	Strict manual zero-based budgeting system focusing on behavior change rather than automated AI.

Interview Script and Guidelines

[00:00 - 02:00] Warm-Up & Context

[02:00 - 07:00]

Product Usage & Core Mechanics

[07:00 - 12:00] AI/Automation Experience & Pain Points

[12:00 - 15:00] Decision & Value Assessment

Interview 1- Cleo User (Direct Competitor)

- **Goal:** Understand how users interact with a conversational AI agent for spending and saving.

Questions:

1. **Background & Setup:** How long have you been using Cleo, and what made you choose a chat-based app over traditional spreadsheets or bank apps?

2. **AI Engagement:** How often do you interact with the chat interface (e.g., asking *"Can I afford this?"* or receiving auto-roasts)? Does the personality keep you engaged or ever feel gimmicky?
3. **Saving Nudges:** Have Cleo's auto-save rules or chat notifications actively stopped you from overspending? Can you give a specific example?
4. **Frustrations & Gaps:** Where does the AI fail? (e.g., miscategorizing transactions, unhelpful responses, paywall friction)?

Interview 2- Monarch Money User (Direct / Adjacent Competitor)

- **Goal:** Understand how users evaluate comprehensive tracking apps with AI query features.

Questions:

1. **Background & Setup:** What primary goal led you to pay for Monarch Money (e.g., shared partner finances, net worth tracking, monthly budget)?
2. **AI Assistance Utility:** Monarch has an AI financial assistant. Do you actively ask it questions about your finances, or do you rely mainly on the visual dashboards?
3. **Actionability:** Does the app actively help you save money every month, or does it primarily function as a reporting mirror after spending occurs?
4. **Frustrations & Gaps:** What feature is missing that would make budgeting feel less manual or tedious?

Interview 3

- **Goal:** Understand why users prefer disciplined manual budgeting over automated AI tools.

Questions:

1. **Background & Setup:** Why did you choose YNAB's strict zero-based budgeting method over automated AI apps?
2. **Behavioral Impact:** YNAB requires manual/intentional category assignment. How does that friction affect your daily purchasing decisions?
3. **Automation Views:** Would you trust an AI agent to automatically allocate your income or budget categories for you? Why or why not?
4. **Frustrations & Gaps:** What is the hardest part about sticking with YNAB, and where do you usually fall off or get frustrated?

Detailed Evidence Log

Artifact ID: LOG-01

- **Competitor Evaluated:** Cleo (Direct Competitor)
- **Participant:** CS Undergraduate Student (Uses Cleo for micro-savings)
- **Interview Duration:** 15 Minutes
- **Teardown Completed:** Yes (30-min onboarding & chat flow evaluation)

1. Verbatim Evidence & Observations

"I loved the 'roast' feature at first because it was funny, but after a month, asking the chat bot 'can I afford this' felt like too many steps when standing in line at a coffee shop. I just want the app to tell me my safe-to-spend limit automatically." — **Participant 1**

2. Teardown Findings

- Onboarding takes <3 minutes with bank link.
- High engagement initially, but chat interface adds interaction friction for quick checks.
- Auto-save rules (round-ups) work silently in the background and are the most retained feature.

3. Product Takeaways & Actionable Decisions

- **Insight:** Chat-only interfaces introduce friction for instant decision-making.
- **Decision for Our App:** Implement a **"Safe-to-Spend" widget/dashboard card** for instant visual feedback, while reserving the AI Chat agent for deeper weekly summaries and personalized goal setup.

Artifact ID: LOG-02

- **Competitor Evaluated:** Monarch Money (Direct / Adjacent Competitor)
- **Participant:** Working Professional / Graduate Student
- **Interview Duration:** 15 Minutes
- **Teardown Completed:** Yes (30-min budget allocation & analytics breakdown)

1. Verbatim Evidence & Observations

"Monarch gives me amazing charts, but it's completely backward-looking. By the time I see I overspent on dining out, the month is already over. The app doesn't proactively intervene or help me adjust my budget mid-month." — **Participant 2**

2. Teardown Findings

- Comprehensive financial aggregator, but requires heavy manual setup for monthly budget caps.
- AI assistant feature is hidden deep in settings, leading to low feature discovery.
- Lacks dynamic mid-month recalculations when a user overspends in a specific category.

3. Product Takeaways & Actionable Decisions

- **Insight:** Static dashboards show history, but users need real-time behavioral intervention.
- **Decision for Our App:** Build an **AI Mid-Month Auto-Balancer** that detects overspending early and suggests dynamic reallocations (e.g., *"You went $30 over on dining out; move $30 from entertainment to stay on track?"*).

Artifact ID: LOG-03

- **Competitor Evaluated:** YNAB - You Need A Budget (Indirect Competitor)
- **Participant:** Former YNAB user who stopped using the app due to complexity
- **Interview Duration:** 15 Minutes
- **Teardown Completed:** Yes (30-min category assignment flow)

1. Verbatim Evidence & Observations

"If I miss logging transactions for a week, catching up feels like homework. I gave up because fixing miscategorized items and unallocated dollars felt overwhelming." — **Participant 3**

2. Teardown Findings

- Strict zero-based budgeting requires manual approval for every transaction.
- Steep learning curve creates high churn during the first 30 days.
- Absence of automated AI sorting forces high cognitive load on the user.

3. Product Takeaways & Actionable Decisions

- **Insight:** High manual maintenance causes user burnout and app abandonment.
- **Decision for Our App:** Implement **Smart Auto-Categorization with Confidence Scoring**. High-confidence transactions auto-approve, while ambiguous ones are grouped into a quick 5-second "Weekly Review" queue.